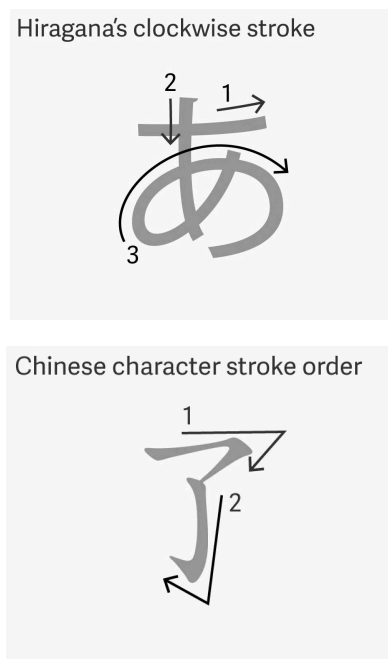
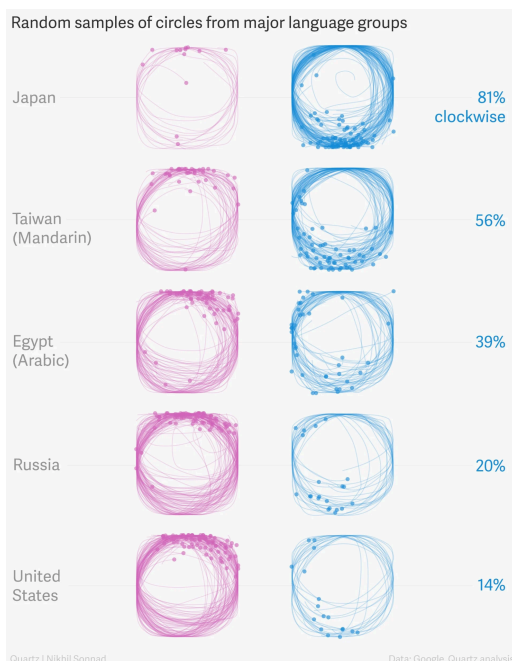


Exercise1

a) The authors link to many examples of interactive articles. Pick at least one of them, based on your own interest in either the topic or the used visualizations / interactions, and explain your choice in one sentence. Describe at least one interaction that is offered by the article of your choice. What did you perceive as its main benefit? Do you see an opportunity for further improving the visualization or interaction?

The chosen article for this exercise is “How do you draw a circle? We analyzed 100,000 drawings to show how culture shapes our instincts”. I chose this article because the analysis made in it shows that the way people around the world draw a simple circle can explain human behaviour and cultural upbringing and, through the visualizations of the data, psychological developments can be carried out.

One key interaction is that the article asks readers to draw a circle themselves before revealing the global data, making them active participants in the story and be part of the dataset. Another interaction is the exploratory visualizations: the writer of the article explains visually how different writing systems work and it is compared with the clockwise or counterclockwise way of drawing, which lets readers investigate patterns between drawing direction and culture. An example is the influence of the asian-style script on the chosen direction.



The main benefit is engagement through personal involvement: because the article begins with your own drawing behavior, the later visual explanations feel more relevant and memorable. The interaction may also make the reader pay more attention to the graphics because they might want to find themselves in the plot.

One possible improvement would be allowing readers to compare their result interactively with users from their own country or language group in real time, or adding filters to explore variables such as handedness or age, which the article mentions but does not let the reader

investigate directly. In this way, the benefits of the interaction explained in the previous paragraph could be reinforced because readers could compare their drawing to the average more precisely.

b) The authors repeatedly highlight findings from psychological and educational research. State two such findings, and explain why they are relevant to interactive articles.

1. Self-explanation improves learning. The authors discuss research showing that when people are prompted to make a prediction or explain something to themselves before seeing the answer, they understand and remember information better. This is relevant to interactive articles because interactions, such as the one from the part a) of the exercise, makes the reader form an hypothesis before reading the conclusions of the real data.

2. The testing effect strengthens memory. The article also highlights the “testing effect”: retrieving information through low-stakes quizzes or prompts (with no grades) improves later recall, and feedback makes this effect stronger. This matters for interactive articles because quizzes and immediate visual feedback can help readers retain ideas better than static explanations.

c) Even though The New York Times pioneered the integration of interactive visualizations into journalism, it has now become more cautious about the use of interaction. What are the reasons for this? Do you think those reasons carry over to other domains, such as science and education?

The article says The New York Times became more cautious with interaction because interactivity can sometimes distract readers, increase complexity, or interrupt the narrative instead of improving understanding. They argue interaction should only be used when it adds real value.

I think this also applies to science and education. Too much interaction can overwhelm users, but well-designed interaction can support learning and exploration. For example, in scientific articles, too many visualizations such as graphs could distract the reader by forcing him to interpret every one of them. If only the needed plots, comparisons and prompts are included, the reader can keep up with the provided information in a more clear and direct way. The key is to include meaningful interaction.